

Pathwork Guide Lecture No. 197
An Unedited Lecture
January 14, 1972

ENERGY AND CONSCIOUSNESS IN DISTORTION -- EVIL

Greetings, all my friends here. Divine blessings and divine force pours forth from the world of spirit toward and into you and from the deepest well within you to infuse your personality. However, this force should not and must not be used to get away from that which you do not want to see and know. It should be used to increase your sense of honesty with yourself. For only then can love grow genuinely. And only then can you have a sure footing within yourself and the world.

This lecture is again a continuation and direct sequence of previous ones, particularly of the last two. As you know from the past, lectures come in sequences; there are particular sequences which then apparently stop, switching over to a new pattern, a new emphasis. And yet all these topics and different sequences form one whole as an ongoing chain or spiral, as all universal movements are spiral movements if they are in harmony with creation.

In tonight's lecture, I would like to deal, again from a different angle, with the concept of evil. Of course we have talked about this before. There are many approaches, many angles, many levels, and many vantage points from which every part of creation can be discussed. Tonight's approach to this topic is particularly geared to the sequence of these last two lectures.

Some philosophies claim that there is no evil, that evil is an illusion. Other philosophies claim that it is a fact, observable for anyone who faces reality. Some religious philosophies contend that evil stems from one principal source, a specific entity, called the devil -- just as good stems from a personalized God. Good and evil stem from two figures, according to these precepts. Others say that the forces of good and the forces of evil exist as principles, as energy, as attitudes.

As I do so often, I wish to discuss again, first, the cosmic, spiritual, philosophical, and general approach, and then bring it to you so as to use it personally in your own path of development. For any philosophy that is not put into practical use remains a shallow abstraction of the mind, not permeating the other levels of personality.

The various concepts of what evil is and where it comes from are all true, provided they are not perceived as exclusive from the apparently opposite approach. If you say that evil does not exist at all on any level of being, this would be wrong. But if you state that in ultimate reality there is no evil, it is true. Any one of these postulates is incorrect when it is seen as the only truth. This may appear as paradoxical, as is so often the case. But when we go deeper and consider the question from a more profound and broader vantage point, what appear as opposites suddenly conciliate and complement each other.

I shall explain presently how these apparent opposites are all true. Let me say first again that the universe consists of consciousness and energy. In the unified state, consciousness and energy

are one. In the disunified state, they are not necessarily one. Energy can be an impersonal force that does not seem to be, or contain, or be an expression of, consciousness. It seems a mechanical force that consciousness can direct, but the energy itself seems totally alien to consciousness, to determination, to self-knowledge -- in short, to everything that distinguishes consciousness. Think, for example, of electricity or atomic energy. Even the energy of mind seems often quite disconnected from the source of its consciousness. Perhaps you can feel into what I mean, to a certain extent. For instance, many of you have experienced that the power of your thought, the power of your attitude, the power of your feelings does not have an immediate effect. It has an indirect effect, which at first seems so disconnected that it requires specific attention and awareness until you truly comprehend what I discussed in the last lecture: the link between cause and effect. Only when your consciousness expands can you sense the oneness of this tremendous mind power and the energy it sets in motion. This works both in a constructive and a destructive way. The principle is the same.

The separated, dualistic human state creates the illusion that energy and consciousness are two different manifestations. The same split in perception exists about life and self; God and man; cause and effect -- and many other concepts or phenomena of life. There are people on this earth plane who experience the universe, the cosmos, creation, as a purely energetic phenomenon. There are others who experience the universe, the cosmos, creation, primarily as supreme consciousness. They are both right, of course. And they are both wrong when they claim that only their vision and perception is the truth while the other is not. Both are one. Since thought is movement and energy, it is impossible to separate consciousness from energy in their essence although in their manifestation there might be an apparent disconnection.

How can all the different philosophies and perceptions of life be true when they seem opposites? Let us look into this more closely. It is quite true that in reality -- ultimate reality in its oneness, its unified state -- there is no evil. Thought is pure and in truth; feelings are love, joy, bliss; will direction or intentionality is utterly positive and constructive. Therefore there is no evil. But the same consciousness can "change its mind," as it were. It can turn into an untruthful, limited thought process; into feelings of hate, fear, cruelty; into negative will direction and intent. In that moment, the same consciousness or aspect or part of this consciousness turns into its own distorted version. Consequently the energy also alters its manifestations.

Thus the manifestation of evil is not something intrinsically different from pure consciousness and energy. It has only changed its characteristic. Hence it is as accurate to state that in reality, in essence, there is no evil, as it is to state that on the level of human manifestation there is.

The reality of evil, as manifested on this plane of development, must be accepted by each individual in order to learn to cope with it and thus to truly overcome it. Evil must be faced and overcome primarily within the self. Only then can evil be dealt with outside the self. The attempt to reverse this process must lead to dismal failure, for everything must always start from the center out -- and the center is the self.

Now, how about the question whether good and evil are personified, actual entities or whether they are just principles? Again, the answer must be: both. Every man and woman is a manifestation of God, but the distorted state implies that every man and woman must also express the devil. A being who is completely unified and pure would express God in a total way. God can

thus manifest as an individualized form. Conversely, an entity who has distorted his consciousness and energy movement to the extreme degree could be called a devil.

Neither one of these two extremes in the spectrum exist in the human consciousness. The human consciousness finds itself in a state of development where both the pure and the distorted, the good and evil, God and the Devil exist. It is the task of every human being in the long road of evolution, lifetime upon lifetime (and indeed it takes thousands of lifetimes, not hundreds) to purify the soul and to overcome evil.

Let us look for a moment at what evil means, both from the point of view of energy and from the point of view of consciousness. When energy is turned into a destructive manifestation, its frequency slows down, commensurate with the distortion of the consciousness which determines this state by the choice and will direction of the thought process and attitude pattern instituted. The slower the frequency of movement, the more the distortion of consciousness has advanced, and the more we can speak of a manifestation of evil. Another alteration of the energy flow in its distortion, or in its evil aberration, is the way it condenses. The higher developed the entity, the purer the energy, the faster its frequency, and the more radiant its matter. The more distorted, the more destructive, the more evil, the slower its frequency, and the more condensed is the form in which the consciousness manifests.

Matter, as you know it, is therefore a rather advanced state of condensation. Condensation of energy means the dualistic, disconnected, disunified state; and the consciousness involved in this state has to find its way back to increase the frequency of the energy movement and to alter the thought and attitude pattern so as to purify consciousness and energy.

What does evil mean in terms of consciousness? Religion has of course talked amply about this -- in terms of hate, fear, selfishness, deception, duplicity, spite, cheating life by not paying the price, by wanting more than one may be willing to give, and many other destructive, hurtful attitudes. This is so obvious that it hardly needs further elaboration. But let us look closer at the phenomenon of evil on a more subtle level so as to help you further on your inner road.

Jesus Christ has spoken the words, "Do not resist evil." This saying has been misunderstood in many ways. It has been interpreted in a too literal and therefore erroneous way. It has been taken to mean that you should allow others to exploit you, to step over you, not to assert your human rights and your human dignity. It has preached a meekness and masochism that are not in keeping with divine truth. On the contrary, they help to perpetuate evil and allow the perpetrator to act it out upon his environment.

Any truth can be interpreted in different yet correct ways, according on what level this is done and from what vantage point it is approached. Since we are discussing tonight evil as a manifestation of consciousness and energy, I shall interpret "do not resist evil" from this angle. "Do not resist evil" points very clearly to the fact that resistance itself is and breeds evil. From the energy phenomenon, this is as obvious as from the phenomenon of consciousness.

Unobstructed, unresisted energy flows smoothly and harmoniously like a gentle river. When resistance stops the movement of the energy current, the movement slows down, the form

condenses, the energy flow congests and clogs up the channels. Resistance tightens and thus coarsens the manifestation of energy. It holds what should move.

The consciousness responsible, so to speak, for the thickening must exist accordingly. This is not quite correct, but human language is incapable of expressing the essential oneness of consciousness and energy so that we must compromise and regard it as though consciousness were "responsible" for the energy flow. Anyhow, from your vantage point this expression will be quite adequate. The thoughts, intentionality, feelings, and attitudes embrace a resistive attitude to what is; to the truth; to life; to God; to any aspect of the goodness of the universe. This consciousness resists trusting the life process; it issues forth ill will (negative intentionality). There is no evil attitude conceivable unless resistance to good is involved. Conversely, wherever life manifests unobstructedly without resistance, it must be good and blissful, harmonious and creative.

The very manifestation of matter as you know it, which is a highly disunified state, is a result of resistance. Matter is thickened, coarsened, slowed-down energy. The state of existence in matter is blinding: matter blinds true vision and is therefore unavoidably painful. Resistance equates matter, equates blindness, equates dualism and separation, equates evil, equates suffering. Resistance is a stemming against the flow, closing up, tightening up. It prevents the movement of the universal energy: the movement of love, the movement of truth -- the ever ongoing movement of life where divine manifestation unfolds unobstructedly. Resistance is always obstructing some valuable, beautiful aspect of creation. Obstruction evidently blurs out truth, vision, love, life. Resistance is therefore a manifestation of evil.

When you look into yourself, feel into yourself, and go deeply enough into yourself, you will relatively easily perceive your own resistance. Others always can unless they are extremely blind, undeveloped, or dependent on not seeing it. They may have a stake in agreeing with you, in keeping an idealized image of you. But if this is not the case, they are aware of it; you, too, can be aware if you wish to be! You will then see what this resistance means.

The word resistance is used again and again in psychological terminology. Usually people even forget the real meaning. The word is thrown around, and people lose contact with its dynamic reality. Words become meaningless so often when they are used blindly and unfeelingly. This is why I deliberately and quite often change terminology and words, so as to give new impact to your understanding and prevent blind usage. But I use this word in this context because this is precisely the word used by Jesus.

The word evil suffers a similar fate. Religion has thrown it at mankind in such a mechanical, often meaningless and distorted way that many individuals have become practically allergic to hearing this expression. This is why I have shied away from using this word for quite a time and mentioned it only occasionally. But once in a while it is good to return to very basic concepts and expressions so as to lend more impact and new energy to your understanding.

When you face and accept your deeply ingrained negative intentionality you can link this up with resistance. Negative intentionality is perforce a resistive attitude, and it is obviously an evil one. Resistance always says in one way or another, "I do not want to know the truth about this or that." Needless to say, this is a destructive attitude. It must create an evil force. It obstructs the ongoing movement of truth.

In our approach to self-development, we find again and again that the basic evil triad is pride, self-will, and fear. We see how all else falls into this triad. Everyone of these three attitudes (which are always interconnected) is a result of resistance and breeds further resistance -- or evil. Self-will says, "I resist any other way but my way," and "my way" is so often antilife, antiGod. Self-will resists truth, love, union -- even if it appears to want it. But the moment the tightness of resistance, of self-will, exists, divine aspects are hindered from manifestation.

Pride is resistance to the oneness between entities. It separates itself from others, elevates itself, and thus resists the truth and love that are creative manifestations of life. Pride is the opposite of humility, not of humiliation. He who resists humility must be humiliated because the resistance must always finally come to a breaking point. The refusal to expose the truth and to admit what exists is due to pride, and this pride causes resistance as much as it is a result of resistance.

Resistance breeds fear and fear breeds resistance. The tightened state of resistance and the slowing of the energy movement darken the vision and the scope of experience. Life is perceived in a frightening way. The more resistance, the more fear -- and vice versa. Resistance to truth occurs out of fear that truth can ever be harmful (if you think you distrust the universe), and resistance to truth must compound this fear. The hiding becomes forever more difficult, and exposure forever more threatening.

Fear of truth -- hence resistance -- negates the benign quality of the universe. It negates the truth of the self, with all its thoughts, feelings, and intents. This self-negation -- a result of resistance -- is and creates evil.

When you want to avoid your feelings and your hidden thoughts and intentions, you create resistance. Resistance is, in one way or another, always connected with "I do not want to be hurt" -- whether this hurt is an actual one or an imagined one, whether this hurt is due to self-will that says, "I must not be hurt," or to the pride that says, "I will never admit that I can be hurt," or to the fear that says, "if I am hurt, I must perish." It is again an expression of distrusting the universe. In reality, hurt must pass, for it is no more an ultimate state than evil is. The more pain is experienced in its full intensity, the faster it must dissolve itself into its original components -- flowing, moving energy which creates joy and bliss.

Whether resistance comes from self-will, pride, or fear, whether it be ignorance and negation of what is, does not matter. Resistance obstructs God, good, the flow of life. It creates walls, and the walls create separation from truth and from love -- from your inner unity.

A person who finds himself on the road of evolutionary growth, who searches and gropes -- incarnation after incarnation -- for fulfilling himself, for fulfilling his task, is of course in a mixed inner state, as you know. There is a great deal in human beings such as you that is already free and developed. But there is also, of course, as you equally know and experience on your path, distortion, blindness, ill will, resistance, evil.

The human being who is in a partial state of inner freedom -- movement of truth, love, and light, on the one hand, and distortion, negative intentionality, revenge, greed, hate, spite, self-will, pride, and fear, on the other -- must find his way out of this conflict. One part resists the truth that

these feelings and attitudes are there and resists giving them up, while the other part is seriously striving for development and purification. This dual state must cause crisis. I have spoken about this before and devoted an entire lecture to this topic. In the context of the present lecture, let me repeat that such crisis is unavoidable. When two completely opposite movements, directions, and strivings exist, a breaking point must be reached. Such a breaking point manifests as a crisis in an individual's life. One movement says, "Yes, I want to admit what is evil. I want to confront myself and dispense with the pretenses which are, after all, nothing but lies. I want to expand myself and bring forth the best in me so that I can contribute and give to life as I wish to receive from it. I want to give up the childish, cheating position with which I want to grab at life angrily and resentfully while I refuse to give anything to it -- except my demands and my resentments. I want to stop all that and ride trustfully with life. I want to honor God by accepting life at its own terms."

The other side persists in saying, "No. I want it my way. I may even want to develop and become decent and honest but not at the price of looking at this, of exposing that, of admitting anything that is too self-incriminatory." The thus resulting crisis must break down the faulty structure.

In cases where the destructive orientation and aim is considerably weaker than the constructive one, the crisis is relatively minor, for the faulty aspects can possibly be extricated without tearing down the entire edifice. By the same token, if the movement toward growth and truth is considerably less than the stagnant, resistive, evil one, again no major crisis may occur for a while. The personality may stagnate for long periods. But when the movement toward good is sufficiently strong, and yet the resistive quality holds back the total movement, this makes the conscious personality confused, blind, and destructively acting out, and something must give.

Suppose you build a house. Some of the building material is solid, pure, beautiful, and of excellent quality. Some is defective, cheap imitation, rotten. When these two totally incompatible types of material become inextricably mixed, the erected structure cannot stand. If the rotten material can be extricated without tearing down the entire building, then profound crisis and shakeup of the present life manifestation can be avoided. This depends entirely on the conscious determination of the person in question. But if it is too enmeshed because there has been resistance for too long and because sufficient impetus of good will is still lacking, there is only one way out. The structure must be destroyed so that it can be reerected in a pure form.

Such a process calls forth an energy movement that is almost impossible to describe. Resisting evil means not to face and accept the evil in you. This resistance creates a tremendous accumulation of energy which finally comes to a sort of explosion. The deeper meaning of the ensuing destruction is truly marvelous. It destroys the very evil that has created it. Unfortunately it is impossible to convey the configuration that takes place. In the person's manifest life much may go to pieces. The energy movement of the soul substance tears down the rotten structure even if this means that temporarily all seems to go to pieces. What is of true value will automatically and organically rebuild itself.

Perhaps you can vaguely imagine a form of very intense different movements. These movements swirl and rush, explode and implode and destroy themselves as it were. It is like a giant quake where some of the material continues to stand, others break down slowly, still others fast. Movements occur in different directions. Soul substance is torn apart and rebuilds itself

simultaneously in the process. Creation is taking place. Every crisis is an integral part of creation. Therefore, crisis should be embraced and accepted by the wise ones. It should serve to remove more and more resistance. Do not resist evil in you. That means, give up the appearance, the pretense. Give in, go with the movement of life.

The process of destruction/creation is a magnificent sight for spirit eyes. The blind entity may suffer temporarily, but how good it is! The process is awesome in its benign violence. New movements come forth, old movements change direction, color, hue, sound. For in spirit; sight, sound scent, and many other perceptions are one.

If you go deeply into yourself and intuitively feel into the meaning of your crisis, you may gain a glimmer. You will perhaps sense the creative process involved. The creative process must be simultaneously an apparently destructive process -- destructive, as I just said, as far as defective soul material is concerned.

The eternal, ultimate, essentially benign nature of creation is most eloquently demonstrated in the fact that evil must finally destroy itself. It can build up only for so long, but eventually the breakdown must occur. You will all agree that the destruction of destructiveness is a constructive, creative phenomenon.

Thus, in the long run, every destruction is constructive and serves creation -- always. But in the manifestation of an individual's life, this is not always perceived. The further you are on the path, the more you will see this. It will be helpful if you can meditate so as to truly experience this phenomenon because then you will aid the process by your conscious determination to relinquish resisting evil, the evil in you which you project outwardly -- that is, you believe it comes to you from outside, while it can of course never, never do that. It is possible to influence and to diminish the violence of the constructive destruction if your commitment to truth takes on a new impetus and if you unearth your negative intentionality and change it into a positive intentionality. When negative intentionality is expressed in concise words, you can create a new movement. It is up to you. But even before you do so, by your very admission of your deliberate ill will, you will automatically be more in truth and less inclined to act out the evil and even feeling self-righteous about it. You will know who you are. And, strangely enough, the more you own up to the evil, the more honorable you become, and the more you will know it and appreciate yourself.

It is the same with pain: the more you accept it, the less you will feel it. Resistance to pain will make the pain often unbearably painful. The more you accept your hate, the less you hate. The more you accept your ugliness, the more beautiful you become. The more you accept your weakness, the stronger you are. The more you admit your hurt, the more dignity you will have, regardless of the distorted views of others. These are inexorable laws. This is the path we tread.

A lot of wonderful things are happening in this work. But there also must be a lot of cleaning up, so a great deal of vigilance must exist. I want to say that your venture is very blessed.

Now my friends, continue in your wonderful endeavor to be in truth. If you are being doubted in your sincerity, you in your heart must know where you are -- and that is all that matters. That is all that matters!

Be blessed. Be who you truly are -- God!

For information to find and participate in Pathwork activities world wide, please write:

The Pathwork® Foundation
PO Box 6010
Charlottesville, VA 22906-6010, USA
Call: 1-800-PATHWORK, or
Visit: www.pathwork.org

The following notices are for your guidance in the use of the Pathwork® name and this lecture material.

Trademark/Service Mark

Pathwork® is a registered service mark owned by The Pathwork Foundation, and may not be used without the express written permission of the Foundation. The Foundation may, in its sole discretion, authorize use of the Pathwork® mark by other organizations or persons, such as affiliate organizations and chapters.

Copyright

The copyright of the Pathwork Guide material is the sole property of The Pathwork Foundation. This lecture may be reproduced, in compliance with the Foundation Trademark, Service Mark and Copyright Policy, but the text may not be altered or abbreviated in any way, nor may the copyright, trademark, service mark, or any other notices be removed. Recipients may be charged the cost of reproduction and distribution only.

Any person or organization using The Pathwork Foundation service mark or copyrighted material is deemed to have agreed to comply with the Foundation Trademark, Service Mark and Copyright Policy. To obtain information or a copy of this policy, please contact the Foundation.